mistrust and worsening of working relations falls victim to circumstance and accident on the high seas and skies of Asia, a fictional scenario that unfortunately is backed up by plenty of historical precedent. The geopolitical implications of a Sino-US clash are the ultimate focus of this what-if essay.

The prospects for continued stability and growth in Asia look dimmer today than they have for years. Politicians can, and often do, make dangerously misguided choices, and given the continuing legacy of historical distrust in Asia combined with stubborn territorial disputes, there are numerous paths by which conflict could erupt. Despite such worrisome signs of trouble, however, the region remains vibrant and far more integrated than in the past. The shadow of nationalism competes with better-educated middle classes that hope to pass on to their children the gains they have made, while China's mercantilist policies face pushback from nations looking to more open and fairer trading networks. An America that remains engaged in the Indo-Pacific, and which works with partners to help preserve stability, is acting in its own interests as well as contributing to the common good.

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